

BREEDING BIRDS

New spring leaves feed swarms of caterpillars, which hatch from eggs laid before the winter. Caterpillars make ideal food for baby birds, so the woods become very busy as birds, such as this nightingale, compete for nesting sites and gather food for their young.



FAST FACTS

- These forests can grow only in regions with no dry season. The trees can stand cold, but not drought.
- In spring, small birds fly all the way from tropical Africa to breed in the insect-rich forests of Europe.
- Many forest animals store food for the winter.
- Deciduous trees create rich, fertile soil, so a lot of temperate forest has been turned into farmland.

LEAF FALL

As temperatures drop in autumn, deciduous trees lose their leaves. These form a layer of leaf litter, which is rotted down by fungi, bacteria, and other organisms. The decay process releases vital nutrients into the soil. Mushrooms, the fruiting bodies of fungi, push up from beneath the leaf litter to release their spores.

▼ POKING THROUGH

Bright red fly agaric fungi sprout from root systems that feed on the carpet of fallen leaves.



WINTER CHILL

As winter sets in, most of the insects die off. This forces many insect-eating birds to fly to warmer regions, where they stay until the next breeding season. Other birds feast on seeds, berries, and nuts to build up fat reserves for the winter, as do squirrels and bears. Many animals spend much of the winter asleep, but others stay active, providing prey for hungry hunters like this fox.

